

# SO, WHO WEARS THE PANTS?

## THE GENDER DIVIDE

Though the battle of the sexes is often dismissed as a source of lighthearted banter and debate, the fact remains that gender roles are fundamentally important to any society. The way that men and women behave differs naturally, but what is expected of them in a specific culture is what helps organize the society as a whole.

### GENDER SEGREGATION

In many cultures, men have a specific role and women have another. One of the genders is usually dominant and has power over the household. The differences between gender roles can be very extreme or barely noticeable. In more traditional societies, the roles of men and women are clearly defined and easy to observe, while in some Western cultures, roles are blurring and merging, so both genders fill or share a variety of roles.

### BIOLOGICAL BELIEFS

The traditional dominance of the male in some cultures may be traced back to the evolution of society. Many academics have established a link between biology and social organization. In ancient times, men would hunt and search for firewood, while women would stay with the children. As the offspring were dependent on their mothers for food, it has been suggested that women could not assert themselves among the men and were pushed down the social ladder.

### GIRL POWER

Matriarchal societies are quite rare. When women play a more dominant role, they are usually land and property owners. In some matriarchal communities, such as the Minangkabau in Indonesia, men are involved in politics and religion, while women own the land and are in charge of the household and livestock. The land and name is passed from mother to daughter rather than father to son as in patriarchal societies.

